

# FORTY YEARS OF TRANSFORMATION

1986–2026 · PRINT EDITION OF THE NATIONAL RECORD

---

From a nation in ruins to a nation on the rise — four decades of peace, growth and rebuilding, told through the numbers, the milestones and the people. This document is the portable edition of the record published at [fortyyears.go.ug](http://fortyyears.go.ug).

---

**\$330 → \$986**

## **GDP per capita**

Roughly a threefold rise in real income per person, sustained across four decades of rapid population growth.

---

**60 MW → 2,048 MW**

## **Electricity generated**

From one ageing dam to four major hydropower stations on the Nile — a thirty-four-fold rise in installed capacity.

---

**56% → 16%**

## **National poverty rate**

Two in three Ugandans lifted clear of poverty as measured against the national line.

---

**1.8M**

## **Refugees hosted**

The largest refugee-hosting nation in Africa, under one of the most progressive refugee laws in the world.

---

**40**

## **Years of stability**

Four decades of unbroken constitutional order — the foundation on which every other figure rests.

## The starting point. The inheritance we received.

In January 1986 the National Resistance Movement took charge of a state hollowed out by a quarter-century of upheaval: a collapsed economy (\$330 per person), darkness after dusk (60 MW from one ageing dam), and a cycle of instability that had normalised the coup. “This is not a mere change of guard — it is a fundamental change,” the nation was told at the swearing-in. The forty years since are the measure of that promise.

---

## Six eras, one continuous line

---

### 1986

**Foundation.** The National Resistance Movement takes power in a country exhausted by conflict. The work begins with the hardest material there is: trust.

1986 — A fundamental change — the rebuilding of the nation begins. · 1987 — Currency reform and an IMF-backed recovery programme begin to tame hyperinflation.

---

### 1990s

**Stabilisation.** A new constitution, the first direct presidential election, and a public-health campaign the world would study. The state finds its footing.

1995 — A new national constitution resets the legal foundation. · 1996 — The first directly elected president in Uganda's history takes office. · 1997 — Universal Primary Education opens the school gates to millions. · 1990s — National HIV prevalence falls by around seventy percent — a global model.

---

### 2000s

**Growth.** The economy compounds. Farms feed factories; enrolment climbs; a landmark refugee law opens the national door and keeps it open.

2006 — A landmark Refugee Act — among the world's most progressive — is enacted. · 2007 — Vision 2040, the long-term blueprint for a modern nation, is approved.

---

### 2010s

**Transformation.** Power on the Nile. Expressways, bridges and transmission lines carry the decade; the grid reaches districts that had never been connected.

2019 — The Isimba Dam and the Kampala–Entebbe Expressway come online.

---

### 2020s

**Acceleration.** Karuma lifts national capacity past two thousand megawatts. Industry deepens, and the first barrels of commercial oil come into view.

2024 — The 600 MW Karuma Dam lifts national capacity past 2,000 MW. · 2026 — Forty years of nation-building — as commercial oil production begins.

---

---

**Beyond** **The Next Horizon.** The record does not close; it compounds. The next chapter is capacity — industrial, human, and institutional.

2040 — Vision 2040: a transformed Ugandan society — from a peasant to a modern and prosperous country.

## Built on conviction. Delivered for generations.

### 01 · Economy & Livelihoods

*From collapse to one of Africa's steadier growth stories.*

The government of 1986 inherited hyperinflation and a broken currency. Reform came in sequence — recovery programme, currency, revenue institutions — and held. Real income per person has roughly tripled, and the economy has diversified far beyond subsistence farming.

3× REAL INCOME PER PERSON SINCE 1986 · ~6.5%  
AVERAGE ANNUAL GROWTH ACROSS THE ARC ·  
~5,000 FACTORIES OPERATING, FROM 80

### 02 · Energy & Infrastructure

*The lights came on — and stayed on.*

From a single ageing dam generating sixty megawatts, four major hydropower stations on the Nile — led by the 600 MW Karuma — have lifted national capacity past two thousand. Expressways, new Nile bridges and a revived national airline reconnected the country and its neighbours.

2,048 MW INSTALLED CAPACITY, FROM 60 MW · 600  
MW KARUMA — THE NATION'S LARGEST PLANT · 51  
KM KAMPALA-ENTEBBE EXPRESSWAY

### 03 · Social Progress

*Poverty fell from more than half the nation to one in six.*

Against the national line, poverty has fallen from 56 percent to 16. Parish-level programmes, water links, rural electrification and enterprise funds carried the gains beyond the capital, into the villages where most Ugandans live.

16% NATIONAL POVERTY RATE, FROM 56% · 51%  
OF HOUSEHOLDS WITH ELECTRICITY, FROM ~12% ·  
1,200+ NEW PIPED-WATER CONNECTIONS IN THE  
CENTRAL REGION ALONE

### 04 · Health, Education & Human Capital

*A classroom for every child; a turnaround the world studied.*

Uganda was the first country in sub-Saharan Africa to confront HIV openly — prevalence fell by around seventy percent through the 1990s, a decline researchers compared to a highly effective vaccine. Universal Primary Education, from 1997, lifted adult literacy from 43 percent to above 70.

~70% FALL IN HIV PREVALENCE THROUGH THE  
1990S · 1997 UNIVERSAL PRIMARY EDUCATION  
OPENS THE GATES · 70%+ ADULT LITERACY, FROM  
43%

### 05 · Regional Responsibility

*Africa's most generous open door.*

Uganda hosts about 1.8 million refugees — more than any other African country — under the 2006 Refugee Act, widely regarded as among the most progressive in the world. Not camps behind fences: a plot of land, freedom of movement, the right to work. The world calls it the Uganda Model.

1.8M REFUGEES HOSTED — AFRICA'S LARGEST ·  
2006 LANDMARK REFUGEE ACT · BIDI BIDI AMONG  
THE WORLD'S LARGEST SETTLEMENTS, IN YUMBE

### 06 · Stability & Continuity

*The foundation of everything else.*

After decades defined by coups and civil war, four decades of constitutional order became the precondition for every other line in this record. Investment, schooling, health and growth all rest on it.

40 YEARS OF UNBROKEN STABILITY · 1986 THE  
TURNING POINT · 1995 THE CONSTITUTION THAT  
HOLDS

## One country. Many regions. One national record.

### Central Region

KAMPALA · WAKISO · MUKONO · MASAKA  
51 KM KAMPALA–ENTEBBE EXPRESSWAY · 1,200+  
NEW WATER LINKS

The Kampala–Entebbe Expressway — the flagship modern highway. The densest factory belt and industrial parks in the nation. The Parish Development Model rolled out across its districts. Piped-water extensions reaching fast-growing suburbs.

### Eastern Region

JINJA · MBALE · SOROTI · TORORO  
2 DAMS ON THE NILE · 50 MW GRID SOLAR

Isimba and Bujagali hydropower stations on the Victoria Nile. Soroti and Tororo solar plants feeding the national grid. Grain and produce value-addition mills for cooperatives. Jinja's revival as an industrial and tourism centre.

### Northern Region

GULU · LIRA · ARUA · MOROTO  
600 MW KARUMA — THE NATION'S LARGEST PLANT  
· BIDI BIDI AMONG THE WORLD'S LARGEST  
SETTLEMENTS

The 600 MW Karuma Dam — the nation's largest power plant. Recovery and rebuilding across the post-conflict north. West Nile electrification reaching long-isolated districts. Home to Bidi Bidi, among the world's largest refugee settlements.

### Western Region

MBARARA · HOIMA · FORT PORTAL · KABALE  
230K BARRELS/DAY AT PEAK, LAKE ALBERT ·  
NAKIVALE AMONG AFRICA'S OLDEST  
SETTLEMENTS

The Lake Albert oilfields and the nation's energy future. A thriving dairy and agriculture economy. Emyooga and SACCO enterprise support for traders. Gateway to the western tourism circuit — and host to Nakivale.

“I received support through the parish programme, started a piggery, and today I employ three young people from my village.” — NAKATO · MUKONO · PARISH  
DEVELOPMENT MODEL

“When the borehole was drilled, my children stopped missing school to fetch water. Now they study, and we are healthier.” — LOKOL · MOROTO · RURAL  
WATER

“With the new power line, my workshop runs all day. I have doubled my welding business and taken on an apprentice.” — OKELLO · GULU · RURAL  
ELECTRIFICATION

## Four decades. One journey. A transformed nation.

Forty years ago, a nation in ruins. Today, a nation on the rise. The work continues — but the distance travelled is a story worth telling, and worth honouring.



SIGNED INTO THE NATIONAL MEMORY · KAMPALA · MMXXVI  
STATE HOUSE · REPUBLIC OF UGANDA

---

SOURCES: THE FIVE APPROVED FIGURES RECONCILE UBOS, ERA AND OPM NATIONAL SERIES WITH WORLD BANK AND UNHCR DATA — FULL PROVENANCE LEDGER AT [FORTYYEARS.GO.UG/SOURCES](https://fortyyears.go.ug/sources).